The Waning of Mystacor

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Underage

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Angella/Micah (She-Ra), Micah & Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Characters:
Micah (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Castaspella (minor)

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Alternate Universe - Bloodborne Fusion, Don't Have to Know Bloodborne (Video Game), Emotional Manipulation, Manipulation, mind manipulation (subtle but it's there), Implied/Referenced Underage Relationship(s), look Angella is an immortal being at least a thousand years old and Micah is 14, it's problematic, Parent-Child Relationship, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, poor Micah everyone really is just using him, teenage parent (technically), Blood Drinking, Blood, no editing we die like meh, no beast island just an island surrounded by beasts, use of the dead for religious reasons, Manipulative Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Unreliable Narrator, Attempted Murder

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Part 3 of We are born of the blood

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by Nny11

Summary

Mystacor was failing.

No, Micah supposed that was too harsh a word for it. Not failing but fading in a way. Concerning and disheartening but inevitable in this day and age. After all, there was a blood illness spreading now and that was enough for the whole world to hold its breath in terror.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

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The last time a blood illness had shown, the entire world had nearly been destroyed by a plague. The records were unsure what exactly happened. The First Ones Empire had been growing at a voracious rate and they had been fighting on nearly every front when it hit. Many historians and scholars believed the illness itself had been mild, but combined with so much war it had spread quickly and devastatingly. Another theory had been born of the collective use of animal imagery that sprung up around that time to claim the local wildlife had also become sick and attacked. Some claimed that it caused people to become animals instead.

It had been the sort of thing armchair historians spoke about ad nauseum while actual scholars worked hard and quietly to make factual determinations. A safe, if horrifying, topic from a bygone era.

Gods preserve them, the poor souls now worked without rest desperate to find a cure.

Micah himself had once had an obsession with the various theories around the great plague. While his father had little time

or love for his children, he had been proud that they could trace their bloodline all the way back to the First Ones themselves and it planted a seed in Micah's mind of his own greatness by dint of blood.

It was ironic that of all people his mentor Light Spinner had been the one to break him of such supposition. The ease with which she dismissed his birthright and heritage had been shocking, and her ever deepening knowledge of blood a siren's call for someone already invested in its properties.

The Provost had been working closely with Lord Prime as he started a small religious movement, and while their original name had clearly spoken to their intended purpose, the Church of Healing quickly found their name changed in the mouths of suspicious Etherians until they took to it with pride. You see, they saw no end to their good fortune. As Prime's supplied blood and newly minted blood ministers began healing those at death's door, their numbers swelled. The power they gained so rapidly had been an explosion in the face of tradition, to the point that Lord Prime was gifted by vote an entire township which he turned into the Cathedral Ward. With that he gained legitimacy and popularity until it seemed as if all of Etheria had become hooded members.

His father had not been among them, scoffing and one of the many pushing back against the so called "Healing Horde of Idiots". And after years of insult, Prime had laughed genially as he referred to his own flock as the Healing Horde. Micah can remember the day well, his father deep into his cups and enraged had been a terror that night.

But his hatred only grew Micah's own curiosity. He had watched, curious, as a young boy whenever chapel doors were left open. The clean white of their robes, fragrant incense, and grandiose statues drawing his interest as much as his father's spit curses.

The Horde was nothing like the religion they practiced, something old and hardy for ancient gods who were accustomed to their own worship.

He can remember what it was like to go to the consecrated graveyards to those who donated their bodies to their faith, although the numbers were ever dwindling. The sounds and smells as he helped to move worm riddled soil, allowing his father to find and open the casket. Rarely was a whole body required for any ceremony or service, small parts could be taken with respect and gratitude to be left as offerings to the gods. It was not frightening, nor was it disgusting, it was peaceful.

It held none of the pomp and celebration that the Horde had at their services. Showcasing miracles and healing all who wished for it before the congregation. Already in decline, their old and fading ways were out of favor, but with the Healing Horde to compare it to, well, it went with a whimper.

Having grown up believing his faith unshakable, he'd asked Provost Spinner why she aided Prime when she still practiced the more ancient arts. She had smiled at him, eyes crinkling above her veil. "Micah, one can believe in more than one thing, and faith in the gods does not mean I must turn my back upon scientific discovery. Lord Prime has found something wonderful, and I wish only to aid in spreading it broadly."

He felt foolish for feeling that was a revelation, but he'd only been enrolled in the college a few months at that point and her answer opened his eyes.

Micah had trained diligently with her, and as such, he had eventually become familiar with the Horde's workings as well. Miraculous healing through the good blood, a feat that had been allegedly done by the First Ones before the arts was lost forever. Yet so too was it all a front, fake smile and overly sweet words. A nest of vipers hidden by a field of flowers.

He wondered, when news of his father's passing came alongside his little sister to the college, if the man he'd once feared had come around to the Horde for their revival of his beloved First Ones mystical powers. Micah doubted it. His father had been stubborn and hateful, only sending Micah to the college in a desperate bid to have more money for tonics and cocktails. He'd never believed in the power of the arcane arts but the college welcomed all to their bustling halls. Any age and any level was brought into their arms with a promise of service to the school upon the completion of their studies. It had been a dazzling change at the time.

And now, Mystacor was shrinking at truly astonishing rates. Those who already chose to change their field had left, his mentor included, and so few wished to come to the now antiquated College of Magic. Micah had even selected a Chancellor who was more forward thinking and technologically minded in a doomed bid to increase their recruitment, retention, and graduation rates. While Entrapta's work had drawn a few souls to Mystacor they

worked primarily underground and soon fell off the rosters once more.

Sometimes he felt like a ghost, forgotten and lingering in the old halls hoping to find someone. Other times he felt like a man possessed. Shirking sleep for days at a time as he frantically worked to save his beloved college.

He disliked the state of affairs, but it was not such a terrible thing, he supposed. It was a forced bit of optimism, but that could be good for the soul. The once full hallways allowed students and scholars alike to breathe. There was an allowance for instructors to work more closely with their pupils and give them opportunities that they could not afford with even one more person in their classes. The downtime in the afternoons and evenings allowed all of them to take on independent studies from a wide variety of disciplines or to perform a more serious study. With Entrapta and her lot working endlessly in the catacombs, there wasn't even a need to leave the college grounds unless one truly wished to.

It was peaceful in a way that Mystacor was unfamiliar with, intimate and tender. It was truly an atmosphere designed for learning.

He was simply…lonely.

Micah finally made it to the lakeside, eschewing his normal spot on the balcony to stand in the forest at its shore to stare longingly across the waters towards Brightmoon where his heart pleaded with him to go.

He missed his family. Gods, he missed them so much.

Micah had barely been a teenager when Provost Spinner had come up with a clever political ploy. There was rumblings of disquiet over the College's open support of the Horde and bent towards Etherian well being above all, despite the way all their supposed support was provided outside of Mystacor's coffers and by individual scholars furthering their own research. But people do love the comfort of complaining. Spinner had taken it hard, taken it personally as if they were attacking her and not her policies. Many nights he had sat with his mentor as a child, comforting her in her sadness and rage.

It took time for her overtures to be returned, but eventually Light Spinner had secured official visits from both Lord Prime and Queen Angella. An offering of neutrality and acceptance that had done well to stop many in their tracks. They had even laughed a bit together over how so many people who once derided their insular nature were now outraged that anyone from Brightmoon would be allowed to wander so freely in the college.

"You see, it's not that they ever wished for me to be neutral," Light Spinner had chuckled as she looked at the most recent cartoon depicting her as some many armed monster clutching at various powerful political people in the newspaper, "they merely wished for our outspoken favoritism of *them* . They are frightened by the notion that they are not special. Truly, a pity."

And currying favor with the two military powers on either side of the school would allow them more maneuverability when the next

inevitable war arose really was just good business sense.

He'd been excited for the visits, vibrating through his skin when Lord Prime arrived. The man was well loved by the people, his work was literally bleeding edge, and he held Light Spinner's respect. Micah had been waiting with baited breath to meet the man who was changing the world only to be summarily dismissed and ignored beyond a basic introduction and request for him to "run along now". At fourteen it had felt like the end of the world, and so he'd gone and sulked in the libraries and laboratories until his private session that evening with Provost Spinner.

She'd assured him that nothing was wrong with *him* , laughing both fond and bitter about the so-called courtesy and etiquette of their guest. "He used to treat me much the same, it is his way as a foreigner." It was placating and he was unsure how much stock could be put into it, but it did help soothe him enough to be prepared for the Queen of the Angel Bloods to visit the very next month.

He had not, however, been prepared to fall in love.

When she'd stepped into the Provost's Office, Micah had forgotten how to speak, to breathe, to do much of anything besides stare intently while blushing deeply. She was almost three heads taller than him, thin and willowy, with skin a little too pink to be human. And if that was not enough the large celestial wings behind her would've been a dead giveaway. They swirled with purple and pink and blue stars fading in and out in mind bending clouds. She'd kept them folded tightly against her back, mostly hidden by a cloak in concession to their feeble minds. But oh, she was still too beautiful for any mortal to behold. When she'd turned to greet

him, Provost Spinner proudly introduced her protégé and Micah had desperately tried to remember what exactly he was supposed to be doing.

There were rules for greeting and working with royalty after all, and they wished to avoid an incident. Gods, what in the hell was he supposed to do after being greeted?

"Would you like some tea?" He asked, something he was supposed to offer after introductions but it was all he could remember from all their training and drilling over the past two weeks. Micah could feel his mentor's incredulous glare and floundered; blushing and sputtering, "I mean- uhm! Hello and, ah, and welcome to, uh, the College of Mystacore? Mystacor College? The College of Magic."

It truly would have been too much for the ground to simply split open and throw him into the most dangerous of the lower depths in an act of mercy. He felt ready to cry between his own humiliation and Spinner's disapproving, cold glare. There would be hell to pay for botching the whole thing, surely.

But somehow, someway, the visit was not ruined at all. Queen Angella had smiled kindly at him, eyes filled with a warm delight that made his fingers tingle. He wasn't hurt when she had a small laugh at his expense. It was gentle and soft, like the distant chiming of bells and quiet patter of a summer time drizzle.

Her wings fluttered and settled as she nodded to him afterwards, "Thank you, and yes. I would love a cup of tea."

How strange that something so innocuous could change the course of his life. That moment was forever burned into his mind.

It had been the start of something beautiful and illicit.

He was training to become the new head of the college, a position that typically did not allow for family or lovers. She was the ruler of a somewhat hostile nation. They had no way to communicate easily, no way to spend time together. He was hopeless at wooing her but the efforts he made apparently worked well enough. Queen Angella made time for him throughout the visit, showing him interest and kindness beyond what anyone else had ever shown.

And, of course, he had been nearly a child at the time they'd met, and Angella was an immortal angel at least a few thousand years old.

Micah pushed, he was helpless to do anything but push and try and yearn. When she left he felt cold and lethargic, falling ill in his own despair that they would never speak again, only brightening into himself once more when she began to send him letters. He was grateful to be able to grow a full beard out as it helped make him look older and more mature, and he hoped it would please the queen. He wrote back to her religiously, sent gifts and baubles he found or created, and he even sent her his own personal tea blend.

Angella responded to his overtures reservedly but still in kind. A letter back, a thank you, a mention of when she'd used his tea, and her own personal blend eventually made its way into his greedy hands. Her interest never waning or turned, writing that he was special to her.

It felt like an inevitability, their love.

Likewise, it was inevitable that he would experience consequences for something so pure.

Provost Spinner had clearly noticed something, but she couldn't puzzle out the change. No amount of trips into the labyrinth for materials, no matter the additional trainings, no matter the subjects he'd begged to learn finally opening to him changed it. Micah could stand dripping blood in her office to hand over whole chunks of cold blood he'd carved from giants below the city, and still he was distracted from her.

He didn't mean to be, he was simply in love and all else seemed to pale.

Light Spinner, though? Oh she never gave up. Watching a learning, frustrated and colder, harsh until one day she finally found the reason and promptly began to tear his life apart.

"Micah, you do understand that this is for your own good and protection, yes?" Light Spinner asked after she finished

confiscating every token of affection he'd ever been sent. She had found his secret hiding place, and the stash of his most precious items resting openly like precious jeweled eyes on an altar. Now that sat inside her office, listening to the quiet ticking of the clock while they spoke.

He did, intellectually. He understood he was a teenager in some sort from of long distance relationship with one of the oldest living beings in the whole world. He knew about power imbalances, and the potential for abuse. But it wasn't like that! Angella wasn't like that! She made sure they stayed chaste and forced the tempo to slow down no matter what his racing heart demanded. He knew logically how poorly it would reflect on the college if people believed the Provost to be a lackey to Lord Prime and her replacement the plaything of Queen Angella. He **did** understand.

He did.

It just…hurt. Dutifully he'd responded, "Yes, Light Spinner."

She stared at him for a long time, face inscrutable before she slowly asked, "Do you no longer wish to lead this college?"

It sent a thrill of fear down his spine. "No! I mean, yes, yes I do!"

"Micah," Light Spinner leaned forward slightly, tone softening, "It is alright if you don't, it would help with this…situation if you no longer do."

Tears sprung to his eyes at the thought. He'd been working towards this position since he was old enough to want anything at all! Ten years now of work had been put in so far, and there was at least another five before the possibility would open to him. Micah knew, he knew that once he was in charge of Mystacore, he could change the rules unspoken or not. And for Angella he would wait forever, and she had already committed to waiting for him. For her, Micah would move mountains.

"I do still want to lead the College, I can do it Provost Spinner, I can!"

She sighed heavily, one hand massaging her forehead before she reached into her desk drawer to pull out a crystal flask. He could tell it was blood, it was her greatest vice afterall, but there was no label. No indicator of its strength or mix. In fact the bottle was unfamiliar to him as well and it pulled at his curiosity. Light Spinner pulled two small glasses out from the drawer as well, before reaching for her ever present bottle of mineral water. He watched, unsure what else to do, as she poured the water for them both, added a spring of rosemary from the small plant on her desk, and then opened the flask. Immediately he was hit with the sheer arcane power contained within it. It wasn't that it was all that strong, but for blood alone?

He heard whispers in a tongue that felt like it should be familiar, his skin flushed as the room felt suddenly damp, it called to him. Begged for him to come closer.

Light Spinner chuckled, not unkindly, as she quickly but very carefully measured the drops. When she finished she put the flask away, the drawer shutting and locking to all but her magical signature once more, and then held out one of the glasses to him.

"I know you *can* Micah. I am asking you to take a moment and consider what you want. Pursuing the Queen of the Angel Bloods is…politically unwise for the school. There is always the possibility of war on the horizon, and the Whispering Woods can only protect us so far from Etheria, while Brightmoon sits too far across the lake to come to our aid if needed." She wiggled the glass, encouraging him to finally reach out and take it, but didn't let go once he grabbed it. "Listen to me. Ancient blood and angel blood do not mix, child. They attack one another and destroy any foolish enough to lust after both their powers. We require the ancient blood to perform our magic and study deeper into the arcane, this is ancient blood more pure than you have ever tasted. Should you pursue her further, you will be required to take of her fetid blood to swear loyalty to her. It will bar this from you. You deserve to know what you would be giving up, even if this is a pale imitation of the glory that awaits you."

He stayed still as a statue as she let go of his hand, he hadn't known about swearing fealty or that it would bar him from the very thing he'd dedicated his life to. Micah knew the angel blood was another varietal of blood, it was well known that one of Mystacor's very first scholars had stolen it and left to Brightmoon in order to protect their source only to lose control as Queen Angella herself came into her full power. Logically it meant that angel blood was ancient blood, and so he'd assumed any connection between them would be positive.

It left a lead weight in his stomach as he stared into his glass. A crossroads he would need to navigate. His heart screamed in protest even as his whole being seemed to be drawn to the liquid in his hand.

"Drink," she commanded gently, "you need not make a decision right now. But soon you will. And I hope that you will choose wisely."

He didn't want to choose.

At seventeen he had continued his correspondence more subtly with Angella, growing ever closer to his ultimate goals.

At eighteen he took a sabbatical and used part of the time to travel to Brightmoon where they consummated their love. She had been so sweet and kind with him, welcoming him to his adulthood and her heart with open arms. Angella had not been able to hide the way her court disdained him, but her love had been more than enough to prevent anyone from doing anything untoward. By the time he left his love had only deepened for her, and Brightmoon seemed more like his home than anywhere had ever been.

At nineteen his whole world changed. Light Spinner stepped down from her position years earlier than expected, renaming herself in quiet and confiding her plans to him. As the new Provost he had stood both proudly and heartbroken as he watched her leave the college. Already her name had quietly been changed, allowing Shadow Weaver to aid the horde and spread its healing arts further through her own dedicated research. Lord Prime had

requested her assistance directly, and even created the Assembly of the Light specifically to facilitate her studies.

Shadow Weaver, dressed already in the red and white of the Horde, had held him as he cried. “Shhh, it is not forever, my child. No, not forever. But this is for the best, Micah. This is for the good of the world, I can do great things with more resources and you are more than ready for this. I know you will make me proud.”

Gods he hoped he would. He prayed he would.

A few short months later, Micah received an unexpected visitor during the full moon. Angella herself had flown across the lake, a small bundle in her arms to show him. A baby. His daughter, his precious baby girl. They had celebrated, as much as one could with a babe that fussed so readily.

Angella had laughed softly as she finally got her to latch. “Well, she had no complaints with flying. I dare say she will be quite the handful.”

Micah smiled broadly, still in awe as he ran a finger down the newborn’s arm. “She gets it from me, I’m afraid.”

“I’m sure.” Angella had quieted, turning to look at him closely. “What should we call her?”

His eyes fluttered as he searched inside himself, something strange and powerful washing over him as he answered with certainty, "Glimmer."

That night he swore his fealty, drinking Angella's blood from her wrist, and swore they would be married.

A royal wedding had been no small feat, and neither had been the announcement of their engagement and child. If the world stage had not already become worried by the whispers of the blood illness, it would have possibly ended his career and even life depending on who felt slighted. Instead all went smoothly, except for Shadow Weaver.

Oh she had been beyond disappointed. She had been furious. It was the first and only time she'd laid her hands on him, enraged when they'd finally been able to meet and beyond reasoning. Shadow Weaver may have been an administrator and now a researcher, but the woman had never once stopped working on her skills as a hunter. Micah hadn't even had time to think, let alone defend himself from the one flurry of strikes.

About the only good to come of it was how it finally snapped Weaver out of her fury, she apologized profusely, staring in horror at his bleeding nose and swelling face before offering to heal him. He'd accepted, more to stop her apologies than anything else, it was strange how uncomfortable it made him to hear her apologize. Micah had expected she would cast one of the quick heal spells she'd taught him, things that drew a bit on one's own energy reserves but would heal injuries much faster than normal, only for her to pull her small leather pouch off of her belt and withdraw needles instead.

“You’re a minister now?” He asked, eyesight fading in and out a bit as he sat heavily and watched in surprise. “Master Weaver, is there anything you cannot do?”

She’d huffed a laugh at that, and it made him feel better than any tincture ever had. “I’m afraid I’ve yet to master immortality. Now please, hold still.”

It wasn’t until he felt the burning sensation that he remembered his oath. Micah waited for it to grow wildly out of control, to kill him on the spot, only for his bones to snap back into place and survive with little more than a dull ache.

They had both been shocked in the aftermath of that, and their fight rapidly dissolved, forgotten in their excitement to have discovered such a strange interaction. By the next morning they were both exhausted in one of the many empty labs, recording the results of their final test and punchy on their own exhaustion. As they settled in for an unexpected nap, Weaver had finally given her blessing.

She had even attended the wedding in Brightmoon, even if she had been tense and snippy the whole time although Brightmoon’s court seemed enamored with her. Weaver had always had a head for such delicate maneuvers and when she presented her gift of a power mage staff to the Queen and King Consort it had more than made up for any mistrust Angella still held after hearing of their fight.

But the illness was spreading and Micah had no one ready to take over the college considering his recent appointment. And so the happiest days of his life ended with him miserably returning to the college to keep it alive.

The students, staff, and faculty were grateful for his return and that was about the time he began training his younger sister to take over as Provost. If he could simply get her up to speed, he could go home and be with his family and for all she bickered with Angella, Castaspella was dedicated to helping him be with her and Glimmer both.

He hadn't wanted to choose until he experienced the life he truly wanted to lead, and it was far too late by then.

And now, three years later, the situation had only become more dire.

His ribs ached as he finally sank to sit on the shore. He was at the edge of the forest and Mystacor in case anyone needed him, but for now he had one goal.

Micah looked across the moon lake one last time before letting his eyes slip shut to meditate. Slowly breathing in and out, not forcing it to be slow, but merely allowing it to stay and deepen as he dove within his mind. Meditation was something Light Spinner had taught him, but he had learned to use it for his own purposes.

"Remember Micah, all can seek truth within themselves, most do not consider the dangers they will face." Light Spinner spoke slowly and clearly as she taught him late that night, later than was considered correct. It was one of the few sessions they'd had to hide from the others lest someone claim favoritism. "Focus on what you seek, but not at the cost of forgetting yourself."

What he sought was known, no danger of forgetting himself as it required his very essence. There. Warm and pulsing in his veins. The misshapen and infected cells flowed with and around his own. The angel blood sang gently into his ears but he forced the sound away, the song was beautiful as always and still dangerous too. He cared not for the power it promised, nor the security it offered. He was not here for it, he was here to feel his connection to his family.

He opened his eyes to look at Brightmoon Castle, flickering and warping within this temporary dream, and his heart thrummed. Tears leaked from his eyes as he smiled. "Good morning Angella, good morning baby girl."

Angella had told him in the last letter that Glimmer had started to join her morning prayers; he hoped she could feel how much he loved her. "Daddy misses you both. I hope you can visit soon." He could hear footsteps behind him, and the blood in his heart stuttered, the soft song churning and revealing the staring eyes and teeth below. It was unfortunate how short it always felt, but that strong of a reaction would only mean one person was here in particular. One that brought excitement. "I have to go, see you soon."

He focused on leaving. Extracting himself from the blood and the binding oath, and on not letting the identity of his visitor slip. While Angella had explained that no words could make it, only the faintest outline of his feelings, Micah knew that his nervousness would show. Shadow Weaver's gift had calmed the waters, but Angella had never liked the woman.

Finally the dream faded and Micah sighed, standing slowly to avoid worsening his injury, as he worked to not seethe with anger. He loved Weaver, and it had been far too long since they'd last seen one another. It wasn't her fault that he was still trapped at Mystacor, she had been the first and only person who even offered him another option. Almost pushing for him to leave the college for Brightmoon and he had refused her. Perhaps it was his ego, but he'd truly felt he would chose most wisely by not choosing at all, and now it was his own fault. Shadow Weaver was not at fault, merely a reminder of what he could have had.

Micah traveled as often as was safe and considerate to be at home with his wife and daughter, it simply wasn't enough when each time he returned Glimmer had changed so much.

It was only a matter of time now. Castaspella was learning and taking on responsibility at a healthy rate, and Entrapta herself seemed to forget that she was supposed to be doing her own fair share most of the time. It was just…gods, he just needed to be patient a little longer. Maybe another year or two and Casta would be a fine provost, better for the college than he was by a long shot. His blood felt hot as the angel blood cried out in despair, but there was no helping it. He knew his oath, and he knew his own arcane powers were enough to keep balance for a while longer yet.

He turned slowly and waved, hoping none of the hissed warnings would be heard by someone so attuned to it.

"Micah!" Shadow Weaver called to him, mouth already curled into a fond smile. She walked with purpose and poise, her red minister robes swirled behind her in hypnotic patterns.

"Weaver, welcome back." He limped towards her, more intending to sit at one of the nearby chairs than anything else, but he winced at his mentor's sharp look.

"You are injured. Again." Weaver shook her head and helped him cover the distance more quickly, gaze sharp as she took in his splint and bandages after he finally managed to sit. " *Micah.* "

Ouch, he hated the way she sounded so disappointed in him. "Yes, nothing major and you know lesser blood ministration does not agree with me."

Was it absolutely a ploy to compliment her? Yes, but that made it no less true either. Weaver was the only one who had ever been able to use blood to heal him after he'd bound himself to Angella. For some reason her own was the only that did not cause complications and pain. One of their discoveries when testing his blood was how violently it reacted with ancient blood despite seeming to permit her own good blood. Strange, yes, but it did mean he was left behind from the latest medical advancements sweeping the world one person at a time.

He smiled broadly at her dry look, able to see his words had still calmed her somewhat.

"Flattery will get you nowhere with me child." Shadow Weaver sat across from him, rolling up her sleeve enough to tie the band before moving to his arm to repeat the process. Contrasting spectacularly to her words, Weaver was gentle as she could be with the needles. Efficiently drawing a small amount of her own undiluted blood and soon it flowed into him. Waves of soothing coolness that healed further, accelerating the rate of his own natural regeneration. "By tonight you should be most of the way there. Be more careful in the labyrinth, it should not-"

"Be taken lightly, trust me, I know." Micah firmly held the bit of cotton to the infusion site, his corrupted blood tended to resist coagulating and he was tired of losing clothes to the stains thank you very much. "I did not go down, out of the utmost respect of course."

"Yes," Weaver playfully sneered, "I'm sure it had nothing to do with the Dryl prospectors at all."

He gasped theatrically, "Oh no, never that! They are so very considerate of the college you know, quiet as a mouse, and pay utmost attention to where others are."

They both chuckled, Entrapta had always been fully herself and that had attracted many interesting types to her personal brand of

research. It was an ongoing and healthy debate between them as the prospectors who had so easily followed Weaver had all but fled to Entrapta's distracted acceptance of anything and everything. Their ties were still strong, even if the hunters themselves were slowly becoming more reliant on the strange weaponry being developed on behalf of the school.

"If not the catacombs, then pray tell where did you find twenty flights of stairs to fall down? Or did you simply climb to the top floor and tumble five times to test the effects of the first?"

His jovility was sapped a bit, but he forced a smile to stay on his face. Weaver would not be pleased with his choices but there was little for him to do these days. Teach an early afternoon lecture, assist Casta with her work, and stare longingly towards the lake. No, he needed to stay busy. "Ah. Yes, you see, I've joined the volunteer hunting forces. Found a beast of some kind outside the city, turned out there were two."

Shadow Weaver looked away, lips pursed as she clearly thought through what she wanted to say. The official line from the Horde was that the beasts were from the labyrinth below Etheria, surfacing through unknown entrances. Anyone with a thought in their heads could tell that wasn't true. The blood illness, so debated and contested was slowly showing them a harsh reality.

The people of Etheria had started to change, not many, no. Maybe one in several thousand who transform into strange and violent beasts at first. But over the last year it had gotten more common. The Healing Horde itself had formed its own new faction of hunters, Force Captains headed by a woman called Mara which

was a horrible sign. Projections were that within their lifetime all could change on a whim, and no one knew why.

Or so the grape vine whispered.

Micah supposed he was fortunate to know someone so high up within the organization. It was bleak, but at least he had no misconceptions about the realities of their world. And Shadow Weaver had already told him the truth.

There were some brothers and sisters whose blood had become… wrong, rotted or tainted. But distributed out as it was, there was no way to know who had used it. Any who had gone in person for healing during suspected times of the blood were called back to be cared for by the Assembly, observed and treated as symptoms showed. Shadow Weaver had explained, sparing no detail of how her work had changed to experiments with known batches of the beastly blood on convicts and terminally ill volunteers. The transformations into all sorts of strange things, the inability to find a cure, the frustrations that even her own blood bore no fruit.

She had been one of the first tested and cleared, her natural magic and years spent so close to the source making her a more powerful healer than most. Her work to heal children had slowed to a grinding halt, her research pushed aside as she turned her attention to the illness without hope. Shadow Weaver was dedicated to the research halls, but she need not confess for Micah to know she was shaken. Shaken and disgusted by the Healing Horde hiding the truth. Training hunters to "aid in law enforcement" and telling one and all that healing was safe still. Feeding them a palatable lie.

His heart raced, and even if he was sure he knew the answer he had to know. “Master? What is it? What has happened?”

Because the lack of her bite, her disappointment in his decision to rove about in dangerous areas to hunt…

It did not bode well.

“It’s getting worse,” she spoke softly, eyes darting to ensure none could overhear them. “We have taken to calling it the beastly scourge now.”

He’d seen the art carved into the sacred spaces when his father would lay offerings out for the gods. Horrible beasts peeking from below altars, snarling from the ceilings. Their faith had spoken in line with the often dismissed past, that every human was only a beast waited to be freed. A beastly scourge. The faith spoke of it among the First Ones, dismissed as superstition. Gods alive.

Her voice was raw as she whispered, “More turn everyday. Micah...it is not safe to go to Etheria. I fear the worst will happen.”

Every hair on his body felt like it lifted in terror. “What are the projections?”

“It’s not as simple as-”

“Please.”

She looked at him, green eyes practically shining in the early morning light. It was surreal, to feel the cool breeze from the lake and the warmth from the sun. Listening to the idyllic chirping of birds as he took in the worst possible news.

“Within the next 5 to 10 years, we will have a full pandemic on our hands. Sooner still with all these foreigners practically invading the city for healing. Prime heals all, but we have begun to require contracts of service in exchange just to stem the flow.” Shadow Weaver sighed heavily at his inquisitive head tilt and shook her head, the way she used to when it was clear Micah misunderstood a lesson. “They are contracting hunters, Micah.”

That was bad. That was very, very bad. “What are they telling the people?”

Weaver snorted bitterness seeping out of every pore as she explained, “Oh it’s all being dressed up as the hunters being traveling doctors. Those in white will bring those with early symptoms for treatment, those in black will seek out any too close to be saved. They’ve come from far and wide to help our “backwater” city, don’t you know. The Horde has put up checkpoints and security to check the population regularly and the people want *more* . Prime has Etheria paying out the ass for his services, which his blood healing only means more money for him. I doubt he cares about such matters now.”

“By the gods…” Micah’s mind was spinning. Mystacor had no direct path to Brightmoon, the only bridge to it jutting out from a small township at the very edge of Etheria’s borders which necessitated passing through the city to travel. If it was too dangerous, then he couldn’t go home. Not until this plague had been snuffed out. There was no hope for him to leave, and his tenure once more stretched before him as a horrible specter to haunt him.

He forced himself to not spiral, to think of anything else besides the ringing in his ears. Mystacor was safe for now, and while it would hurt him to not go home perhaps Angella could visit him instead? There were ways for him to be with his family and they were all safe.

All except for Shadow Weaver herself, stuck in the thick of it. “Is it safe for you to remain there?”

She chuckled sadly. “Always a clever boy. I must admit, I had...ulterior motives to come and see you today. I will be leaving the Horde and no longer administering nor donating my blood. I cannot support the decisions they’ve made regarding the scourge.”

Micah needed no further proof of how bad things were about to become, but perhaps some good could come of this.

“You know that Mystacor is always open to you Shadow Weaver. You will always have a home here, should you wish to come

back.” It was pathetic of him, the way he hoped she would. To keep her safe, and to give her back the burden of running the college, allowing him in turn to go home to his family to wait out the storm.

“I know, and I thank you.” She smiled warmly at him before laughing, “Don’t think I don’t know what you are trying to do Micah! I’ve grown lazy without needing to do all the paperwork you do now, and I’d simply pass my grading off to you.”

He grumbled good naturedly even if it broke his heart, “Don’t say that, you know I’d find someone to delegate it to as well.”

“Ah, then it will not be up to standards. I’m afraid that seals the deal, I will not be returning.” Weaver tapped her nails against her arms, crossing them as she looked out over the lake. “Besides, I’ve already purchased a home in Etheria, nice and large to start an orphanage. With all that is to come, more and more of them will need a place to live. I’m no stranger to fighting and I can heal them should they need it. The Horde has agreed to pay a stipend to support my efforts, truly the one good thing they’ve done in all this.”

When she looked at him again there was a sadness in her eyes, one hand reached across the gap to hold his. “I will not visit again after this, and I urge you to stay away from the city. I’m afraid this is goodbye for now, Micah.”

It was an arrow in his heart to hear that. He was losing her.

Weaver may be alive but he may never see her again. Micah swallowed thickly, trying to stop the tears before they came. His own mother had died after giving birth to his sister, and Shadow Weaver had taken more care and interest in him that his father ever had. His wife was ruling a distant land, his daughter was growing up without him- and now he was **losing** Weaver too! It was too much. Too much to bear.

"Now, now, dry your eyes." Her words only made them come faster and hotter than before. What was he going to tell Casta? Surely she would be devastated, even if she hadn't known Weaver as long. Stars, how was he going to- to? He tipped easily into her embrace, needing barely a tug to collapse against her. "Come now Micah, no need for such a display. You are not a child anymore, you are the Provost of Mystacor. Cease this foolishness. Breath with me if you must." Her voice was soft in contrast to the words and he did his best to follow the slow and steady flow of her voice as she gave him instructions. He chuckled wetly as he realized they were a somewhat modified version of her meditation lessons.

"S-sorry Shadow Weaver," He coughed and cleared his throat after getting a hold of himself.

"As you should be, most unsightly."

He giggled a little bit, that was Shadow Weaver alright, that biting dry wit ready to go at a moment's notice. "Oh, indeed! I just...it will be hard knowing you are so close and in such danger. Promise me you and your wards will come to Mystacor should things get too dangerous?"

She scoffed before answering, “Only if you promise to cease hunting?”

Ah. An impasse it was then.

But a half a lie might go down sweeter than the truth. “Hunting will help people, protect people. You know I can’t.”

“And I will not abandon a child to the streets, when I can provide protections as well.” She softened her tone, although he could tell it was forced. “I am not here to fight with you about this. It is done. I wish to spend a quiet morning, and have a favor to ask of you.”

He perked up a little, mentally cringing as he pictured Casta’s eye roll. *You are an adult, try to not act like a puppy around her.* His sister had always been jealous of his powers and envious of his special relationship with Shadow Weaver, and sometimes her biting commentary left deep gouges in their wake. Of course he was excited and eager to help, he loved Weaver and she loved him in return. Perhaps not as openly and warmly as most would assume, in public Weaver was taciturn and cold. But he knew the real her, the truest version of herself that she showed in private with those she trusted. He would not lose her to some haunting words from his past.

“Of course, anything I can provide is yours.”

The crease in her brow smoothed, smile blooming just the way he'd hoped. "You always were such a good boy, and you've become a great man. But please consider the request before granting it. Someone may take advantage of you some day."

Micah roughly wiped at the drying tear tracts on his face, chuckling, "It's not taking advantage if I offer, but as you say. What is your favor?"

"I believe…" Weaver hesitated, eyes darting between his as if looking for something.

"Come on, don't be shy now!" He put on his goofiest grin and puffed up his chest. "What's a little request between friends?"

Weaver smiled, almost sharp before it turned into something gentler. "I believe that angel blood may hold the cure to the scourge. It does not mix well with the ancient blood, nor with brothers and sisters of the Horde, and yet you are still able to be healed with it in your veins. My hope is that not so much is needed that all must swear fealty to Brightmoon, but I cannot know unless I can experiment and test. My attempts to help will not cease when I open the orphanage, but this is not some simple ingredient I can fetch at the market."

"Not the first time I've donated in the name of furthering humanity." Micah nodded, "In the evening then, or the morning before you leave?"

“Let us see how you are this evening. Ideally, we will do a session tonight and I can heal you, then one more in the morning.” Weaver squeezed his arms one more time before helping him sit in his chair again. “Micah? Thank you. This means more than you can understand, after all I’ve seen…”

“It’s no problem, if you need more just write with a sigil. I can send more to you without either of us leaving our duties.” If this was truly the last time he might ever see her, Micah would grant her any request. Any boon.

“Gracious *and* thoughtful!” Weaver chuckled, rearranging her robes to sit more comfortably in the mid morning sunshine. “I really should thank whoever raised you, she did an impeccable job.”

They laughed and spoke for the rest of the morning, retreating for a somewhat more frigid lunch than he’d expected. No amount of pleading or asking made Castaspella warm any, and her reaction to learning that Weaver would never return made his blood boil.

“About time,” Casta huffed, quickly finishing the last of her meal as if she couldn’t wait to flee the room, “Do stick to your word won’t you?”

Shadow Weaver had snagged his elbow as he tried to leave and give his sister a reminder of manners, shaking her head sadly as she did. “You cannot control anyone but yourself, and those who

never understand the gifts given to them are likely to be spoiled for it.”

It was true, he knew it was true, and the rage passed quickly as it always did when his sister reminded him of her brash youth. He pushed her from his mind, alongside his fears of solitude, the scourge, and his family. All could wait for one single day. It passed in a syrupy haze, patches missing and spotty as the conversation blended from one topic to another well into the morning just like old times. With their final session completed, he clung desperately to his mentor, and she benevolently allowed it despite never having been one for such physical displays.

He sat, cold and woozy in his room as she left. Resting and drinking water to slake a thirst that wouldn’t leave as his very soul seemed to cry out in pain. His blood fizzed softly, almost as if giving him a break from its unending torrents in respect for his loss. Gods it was strange though, he’d never felt this bad after a donation before but he supposed he had just been injured. It made sense, or at least was a possible explanation.

So ensnared in the pain and sensation of loss, Micah didn’t even notice that he’d missed his daily meditation.

End Notes

Some Angella backstory I don't think I'll have a place for but is important for her manipulation of Micah:

Every ancient one loses its child, and then yearns for a surrogate.

The Heart of Etheria is no different and blessed a mortal with its gift. Aware of their unexplained pregnancy, the scholar fears what will happen as they are part of the new college of magic, Mystacor. An ancient one's child would be studied, ripped apart without care, murdered to further their own knowledge. And so, the scholar fled across the moon lake praying the water would prevent magical interference. When they landed at Brightmoon it was a small fishing hamlet, but the birth of their daughter brought forth many great changes.

We will explore more about Angella's backstory in the next fic, but this was something that Glimmer doesn't know and I want you to understand that Angella is, technically, an ancient one. She's not quite Kin, not quite a Great One by Bloodborne lore/standards but it's my fic and I can do what I want.

This is why she is drawn to try and conquer Etheria again and again. This is why she craves a child but can never carry to term. This is why she latches onto the young and powerful child who falls so easily under her sway. Love was not a factor for her, but she essentially fell prey to her own long con. Her feelings for him only increased when she finally gave birth to Glimmer, a healthy baby girl.

But every ancient one loses its child, and then yearns for a surrogate.

Just something to keep in mind.

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